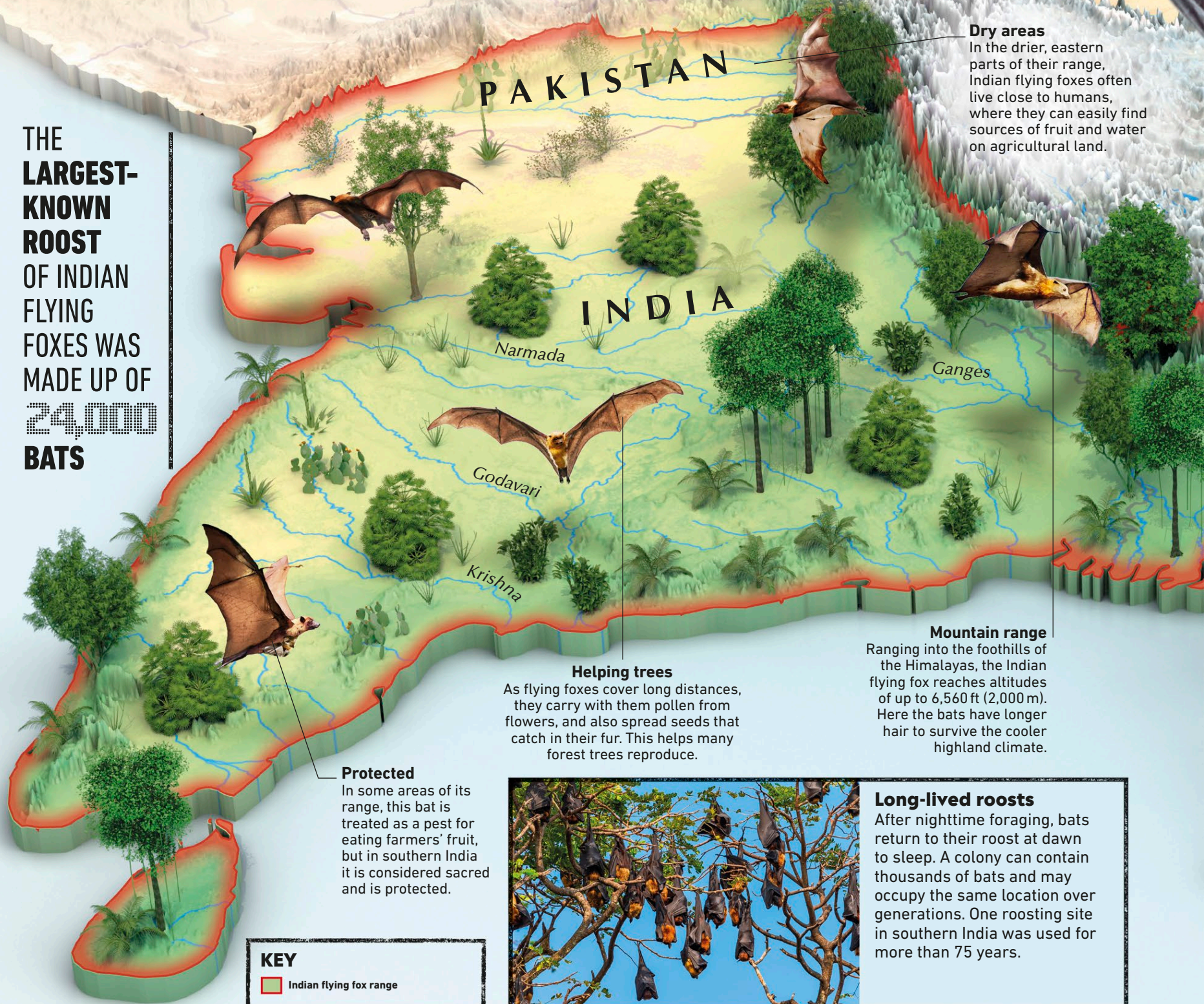


Indian flying fox

With more than 1,400 species, bats make up the second-biggest order of mammals after the rodents, and live in most parts of the world except the poles and remote islands. The Indian flying fox is one of the world's largest bats, and is found in tropical forests and swamps across the Indian subcontinent.

THE
LARGEST-
KNOWN
ROOST
OF INDIAN
FLYING
FOXES WAS
MADE UP OF
24,000
BATS



Dry areas

In the drier, eastern parts of their range, Indian flying foxes often live close to humans, where they can easily find sources of fruit and water on agricultural land.

INDIA

Narmada

Ganges

Godavari

Krishna

Helping trees

As flying foxes cover long distances, they carry with them pollen from flowers, and also spread seeds that catch in their fur. This helps many forest trees reproduce.

Mountain range

Ranging into the foothills of the Himalayas, the Indian flying fox reaches altitudes of up to 6,560 ft (2,000 m). Here the bats have longer hair to survive the cooler highland climate.

Protected

In some areas of its range, this bat is treated as a pest for eating farmers' fruit, but in southern India it is considered sacred and is protected.

KEY

Indian flying fox range



Long-lived roosts

After nighttime foraging, bats return to their roost at dawn to sleep. A colony can contain thousands of bats and may occupy the same location over generations. One roosting site in southern India was used for more than 75 years.